Aleksandre, however, quietly dropped a bombshell. Anastasia could provide intelligence on other countries that Alexei's regime was gleaning from a variety of sources including double agents, but this would come at a heavy price. Khurana knew the agent was pushing the boundaries but he remained noncommittal. In such a scenario, he said, the decision has to be taken by the top bosses. Khurana recalled that the offer was deliberated for some time at the highest levels of the R&AW. Questions were raised as to whether Anastasia's move was 'politically motivated' to spread disinformation. And above all, what was the utility of buying such intelligence at a high price?

'Any slack end may inflict enormous damage to a cordial relationship,' Khurana was warned.

Fearing a backlash, the government headed by Atal Bihari Vajpayee was not interested in continuing the operation. Since spies cannot operate in a political vacuum, Khurana had to accept the government's priorities. When he conveyed the decision to Aleksandre in April 2001, the Georgian said nothing. He just smiled before leaving the Moscow cafe where they had met.

'I ran into Aleksandre in Berlin sometime in 2004. I was sitting in a cafe and having a chat with an old friend when he came over and patted my back. I was happy as well as embarrassed to see him,' Khurana told me. 'He whispered in my ear, "We could have prevented December 2001" and left. He meant that if I had continued running them, we could have prevented the December 2001 attack on the Indian Parliament. Tragedy can often be traced to mistakes we have made in the past. His words haunt me every time we pay homage to our brave security personnel on 13 December. No matter how good the deal was,